

Arrival of the Gotha

From the start of the war, the Germans had wanted to use heavier-than-air aircraft for strategic bombing, but lacked a suitable machine until the advent of *Friedrichshafen* and Gotha twin-engined bombers. The Gothas began raids on Britain in the summer of 1917 with impressive effect. Both the air defenses and the civilian population were unprepared for formations of

bombers attacking in broad daylight. When 14 Gothas appeared over London for the first time on June 13, crowds of people ran out into the streets to watch them. The bombs falling on unsheltered civilians killed 162 people.

The Gothas flew faster than Zeppelins and were far harder to shoot down. When flying in formation, they could dish out heavy punishment to pursuing aircraft from the combined firepower of their machine guns. This relative invulnerability meant that they could operate initially in daylight and later, when air defenses improved, on moonlit, rather than moonless, nights. This made it much easier for them to locate their targets. Also, because they could be produced much

more quickly and cheaply than airships, they could be deployed in far greater numbers – 43 were used in the largest single raid on London.

Sporadic night attacks on London by Gothas and the even larger R-planes (see page 98) continued through the winter and spring of 1917–18. Paris also became a regular target for the German bombers. Parisians and Londoners grew used to a routine of air-raid warnings and all-clears, huddling through the dangerous hours in the cellars and basements of their houses or in the tunnels of underground railroad stations. The raids petered out in May 1918, since, from this time on, all Germany's resources were devoted to the desperate battle on the Western Front. But airplanes had proved their relative effectiveness:

“I would very much like it if you could start up a really big fire in one of the German towns... The German is susceptible to bloodliness...”

WILLIAM WEIR

BRITISH SECRETARY OF STATE FOR AIR, 1918

